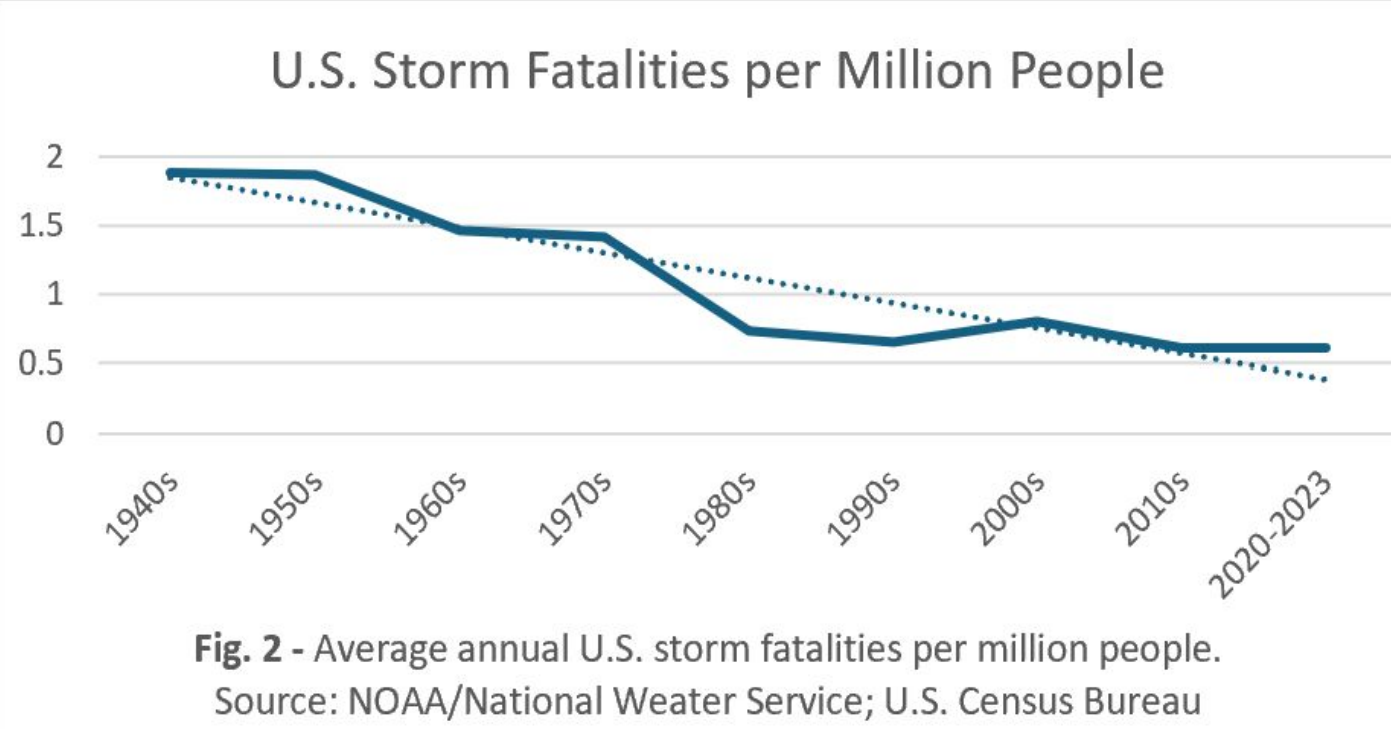
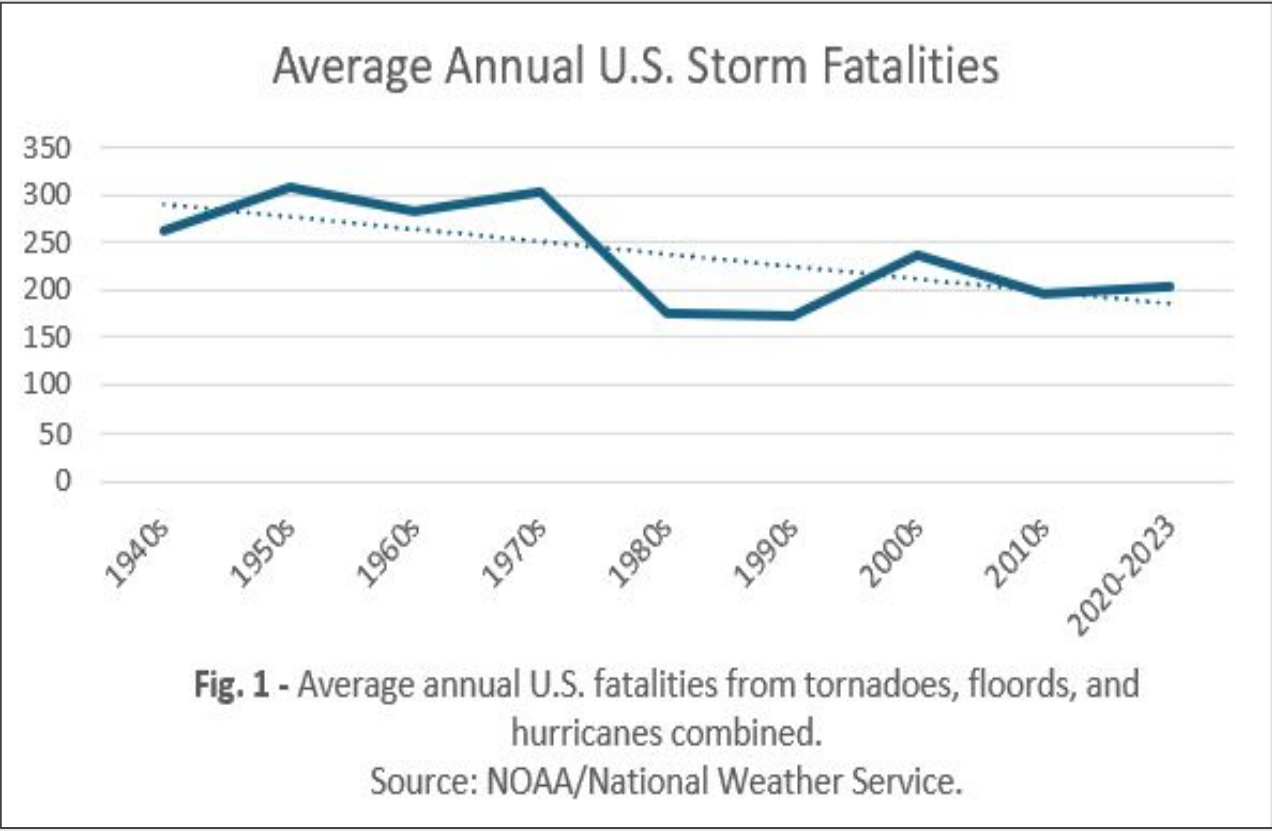


So Why Do We Keep Moving Toward the Water?

EXTREME WEATHER, FLOOD EXPOSURE & THE ECONOMICS OF LIVING WITH RISK

WE'RE GETTING BETTER AT SURVIVING THE STORM

Hurricanes, floods, and tornadoes are not exactly new problems. What has changed is our ability to survive them. Looking at U.S. fatalities since 1940 tells a surprisingly different story from what I expected—and accounting for a growing population makes that difference even harder to ignore. If more Americans can be exposed to extreme weather without a corresponding rise in deaths, something besides the hazard itself must be changing.



BUT THE COUNTRY GOT A LOT BIGGER.

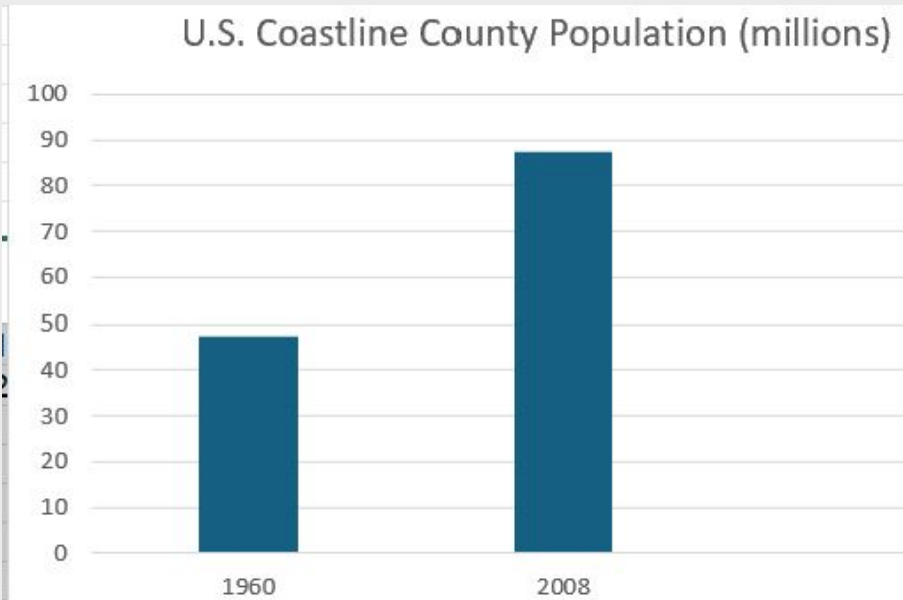
The first graph looks like an improvement, but it is easy to forget that the country itself changed too. The U.S. population more than doubled between 1940 and 2020. Once population is included, the decline becomes much harder to miss. Combined tornado, flood, and hurricane fatalities fell from about 1.88 deaths per million people in the 1940s to 0.61 in the 2010s. Apparently, we did not stop putting ourselves near dangerous weather; we just got much better at surviving it.

U.S. Population (Resident, Millions)	
1940	132
1950	151
1960	179
1970	203
1980	227
1990	249
2000	281
2010	309
2020	331

Source: U.S. Census Bureau.

SO... WHY ARE SO MANY OF US STILL NEAR THE WATER?

Americans remain heavily concentrated near the coast, even with the risks that come with it. But maybe that isn't irrational. If risk were all that mattered, we'd all move inland. People also value beaches, jobs, recreation, community, and other amenities.



Important Caveat
Temperature deaths are statistically estimated; storm deaths are attributed to specific events. They are not directly comparable.

A CLOSER LOOK: CAPE MAY, NEW JERSEY



Cape May shows why “just move somewhere safer” is easier said than done. Coastal storms and flooding are real risks, but so are the benefits: beaches, recreation, tourism, jobs, and community. Environmental risk is one cost in a much larger decision—not the entire decision.

THE ECONOMICS OF LIVING WITH RISK

If risk were all that mattered, we'd all move inland. But beaches, jobs, recreation, and community have value too. The economic question is whether those benefits are worth the added risk, and who pays when things go wrong.

BUT WAIT....

Burke et al. estimate roughly 120,000 U.S. deaths annually are attributable to suboptimal temperatures. So falling storm fatalities don't mean we've conquered weather risk, they show adaptation to only some hazards.

WE GOT BETTER AT SURVIVING THE STORM. THAT DOESN'T MEAN WE STOPPED LIVING WITH RISK.

Sources